Checking for understanding during explanations

Use checks during and between explanation chunks to find out what students can recall, distinguish or apply. Gather evidence that informs a specific teaching decision.

How to do it well

1 Teach it first. Explain or model one coherent step before asking pupils to demonstrate understanding; do not use a cold question to test untaught material.

2 Ask a specific question. Ask what pupils understand, can distinguish or can do—not whether they understand. Script high-value recall, application, misconception and process prompts in advance.

3 Pair-share after silent thinking. Give 5–10 seconds to think, then a brief, structured Turn and Talk with labelled partners and an expectation of full-sentence rehearsal.

4 Pick non-volunteers. Cold call after the rehearsal so everyone remains accountable and the public sample is not limited to confident volunteers.

5 Listen to the response. Attend to target vocabulary, reasoning and the pattern across responses. Probe incomplete thinking instead of fishing for the answer.

6 Give effective feedback and act. Echo a secure answer, elaborate tentative thinking, or explain and reteach an error. Aim for about 80% success before moving on, then continue support until everyone can access the next step.

What this sounds like

“First answer alone. Now compare the reasoning with your partner. I will ask for explanations, then everyone will try a new example independently.”

Classroom example. After a short explanation, students first answer a new case alone. They compare reasoning in pairs, and the teacher samples non-volunteers before a fresh individual check. Responses show whether the difficulty concerns the principle or a missed instruction. The teacher can then choose a specific repair rather than repeat the whole explanation.

Top tips that make the technique work

Distinguish listening from understanding. Repeating what was said checks receipt; a fresh application checks whether the idea can be used.

Plan five useful checkpoints. Do Now review, prerequisites, basics after explanation, hinges and readiness for independent practice offer different evidence.

Use TAPPLE thoughtfully. Teach, Ask, Pair-share after independent thinking, Pick non-volunteers, Listen, and give Effective feedback.

Preserve independent evidence. Collect an initial answer before partner talk where you need to diagnose each pupil’s starting understanding.

Prepare the response. A check is useful when it helps you decide whether to clarify, practise, support or extend.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Check the specific idea just taught.	“Any questions?” as the main evidence.
Respond and use a fresh related question.	Treating a correct volunteer answer as class readiness.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Check for Student Understanding | Barton - Checking for understanding Ten key principles

Barton Responsive teaching